smoke we see coming up the steel mills and the foundries, the jute factories, the new railways and the dams; in the factory-scapes and construction panoramas we see what Nehru meant by the 'temples of modern India', driven by the science and rationality of the day. Rourkela, Bhilai, Damodar Valley Corporation, names we now take for granted in India's industrial anatomy, were things that had to be wrought out of the sorry wasteland left behind by the British.

Janah was an avid student of the work being done by the masters in the West, such as the great landscapist Ansel Adams. His involvement with the Communist Party also exposed him to the photo work from the recently formed Soviet Union, where Stalin's five-year plans were depicted in 'heroic' and 'monumental' framings in cinema and photography. During World War II, Janah became friends with possibly the most famous photographer in the world at the time—American photojournalist Margaret Bourke-White. She sought out Janah to help her with her assignments in India for *Life Magazine*; in return, she supported Janah's work. Ansel Adams articulated the difference between *taking* a photograph—often seen as the capturing of an instant—and *making* a photograph—where the photographer works consciously towards arriving at an image before and around the brief moment of exposure. In Janah's frames of factories and industrial processes from the first two decades of Independence, we can see the distillation of all these influences as he makes the images of the making of a new India. ■

–Ruchir Joshi

ART

KILLING HIS DARLINGS

Artist **Sudhir Patwardhan's** new body of work riffs on the opposing forces of creation and destruction

Sudhir Patwardhan has built a career painting things as he saw them—the harsh realities of the undercity, the faceless crowd, Mumbai's proletariat. "Sudhir is an artist who's trying not to be decorative or unnecessarily intellectual. His work is narrative. He tells a story he knows best. The great thing about Sudhir is that he has stuck to his artistic preoccupations, without ever bothering about what particular style is in vogue," says Arun Vadehra, whose Vadehra Art Gallery in New Delhi is currently hosting a show of Patwardhan's latest body of work.

Rendered with an eye both observant and realistic, *Portraits of an Existential Artist* (on display until February 23) finds Patwardhan turning his gaze inwards. Over the past decade, two important life events—quitting his long-held job as a radiologist in 2005, and becoming a grandfather in 2008—have marked a shift in the tone of his paintings. With the action having shifted from the street to the studio, we have witnessed the artist's contemplative mind at work, seen his private anxieties and demons. After the pandemic struck, Patwardhan, now 73, hardly ventured out. "At first, the lockdown felt good because, legally, you couldn't go out anywhere," Patwardhan says.

SUDHIR PATWARDHAN'S *Portraits of an Existential Artist* gives the maxim 'suffering for art' a new resonance

"Strangely, even though I had all the time in the world, the work turned out to be a little melancholic."

Unveiled at Art Basel OVR 2022 earlier this month, *Portraits of an Existential Artist* seems to give the maxim 'suffering for art' a new resonance. Partly inspired by Hindu philosophy, Patwardhan riffs on the process of creation and destruction and returns once again to the subject of violence. Unlike his depictions of the Bombay riots and railway accidents, this time, the theme feels at once personal and universal—an artist destroying his own work. It is a more "metaphorical reaction than [it is] autobiographical", he insists.

A strong advocate of free speech and a tireless critic of sectarianism and religious violence, Patwardhan's art always had what he calls a "political angle." He says he finds a curious dichotomy in the aestheticisation of violence: "When we go to museums, we find swords and daggers engraved with diamonds and precious stones. Though they are lethal objects used for killing, we can't get enough of their beauty. I want to better understand this contradiction." ■

–Shaikh Ayaz









AS HE SEES IT (clockwise from left) 'Assault'; 'War I'; 'Break'; and (centre) Sudhir Patwardhan